Student Level 140

Reading Comprehension Intervention Passages

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Asha

Unlike some kids, Asha never minded going to bed at night. She loved to lay in bed with her cat and imagine travelling all over the world. Each night she would pick a new location and tell her cat all about the landscape. She would imagine they were flying in her bed and out the window. As she did this, Asha drifted off to sleep and in her dreams she went on all sorts of adventures.

One night she told her cat they would travel to Antarctica. Asha got an extra blanket and they snuggled in because it is cold in Antarctica. Off they went on the bed. They saw glaciers and icebergs. They visited penguins and polar bears. They watched the Northern Lights and even got a ride with a musher in his dog sled.

In the morning, Asha awoke with a start and thought she was still in Antarctica. She quickly opened her eyes and asked the cat how she slept. The cat purred and blinked. They got up and straightened out the bed, which was crooked and away from the wall.

At breakfast, her parents asked Asha if she had any dreams. She told them she dreamed she visited Antarctica. Her dad said he heard her talking in her sleep saying something about slowing down and icebergs. Asha looked at her cat and smiled. The cat purred and winked at Asha. She wondered where they would go tonight.

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Questions for Asha

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Why did Asha not mind going to bed at night?

2. How was she different from other children?

3. Who did Asha sleep with?

4. Do you think having her cat nearby helped Asha's creativity?

5. Where did Asha tell her cat they were going one night?

6. When Asha woke up the next morning, she thought she was still in Antarctica. Why would she think that?

7. What did Asha's cat do when she asked how it had slept?

8. When Asha got out of bed, she saw that it was out of place. How could that be?

9. What did Asha's father hear her talk about in her sleep?

10. Do you think Asha's cat had the same dreams at night that Asha had?

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Ava

Ava was excited. She and her mom were going to plant a flower garden. Ava's teacher had showed the class pictures of her own garden. It looked so beautiful that Ava went home and told her mom about it. Ava's mom decided that they could do the same thing.

First they had to choose a spot in their yard. Ava and her mom finally decided on a corner of the yard that would get plenty of sunshine all day long. Next, they had to dig up the grass that was already growing in that corner. No one warned Ava what hard work that would be! She and her mom worked for hours digging out a small patch of grass and weeds. It was exhausting, dirty work but Ava forced herself to keep going. She told herself she could almost smell the flowers.

Once the grass was removed, Ava's mom said they had to add more dirt. Ava thought that was ridiculous. They had just gotten rid of a lot of dirt with the grass. Now they were going to add more? Ava's mom laughed and said it was special dirt that would feed the flowers and make them grow strong. By the time they finished mixing the new dirt with the old dirt, Ava wasn't sure why she ever thought this was a good idea. Her mom decided that was a good time to quit for the day.

The next week, Ava and her mom studied books on flower gardening. They paid attention to what kinds of flowers grew best in their area. When they'd decided what they wanted, they bought the seeds and planted them. As the seeds grew from tiny green shoots to beautiful, colorful flowers, Ava forgot all about the hard work at the beginning.

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Questions for Ava

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Ava excited about?

2. Why did Ava and her mom choose a spot that got lots of sunshine?

3. What did they have to do before they could plant the flower garden?

4. What did Ava do to keep herself from quitting the hard work of digging out the grass and weeds?

5. Why did Ava think it was ridiculous when her mom told her they had to add new dirt to the flower bed?

6. Why did Ava's mom decide they should quit for the day after they added the new dirt?

7. What did Ava and her mom do next to get ready for the flower garden?

8. Why did they pay attention to what would grow in their area?

9. Once they decided what flowers to grow, what did they do?

10. Why did watching the flowers grow help Ava forget about the hard work that she had done?

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Billy

Billy was a runner. He loved to run and ran almost everywhere he went, to school, his friends, the park, and the store for his mom. Running has always been the fastest and easiest way for him to get around.

Billy's gym teacher thought he should join the track team. Billy however thought that racing on the track team would ruin his love for running. Then he met Rob, the neighborhood showoff. He was always bragging that he was the fastest runner around. Billy finally had enough, he didn't want to hear his boasting anymore. So, he joined the track team.

The track coach started the boys running short distances. The first race was just 100 meters. Rob beat Billy easily, Billy was flabbergasted. Maybe, it was a fluke, a happenstance. The next race was a 400 meter race. Rob barely beat Billy. Rob couldn't contain himself, claiming that he is by far the fastest runner. Billy was losing his confidence, but was determined to try his best.

The next day, Billy trudged to track practice, feeling defeated. The track coach decided to have his runners try long distances. He started out with a one mile run. Billy and Rob remained even with each other until the last few seconds when Billy pulled ahead. A smile crossed Billy's face. The boys lined up for a 5K, the gun sounded and off they went. They were headed through the woods, down the gravel road. Billy was feeling comfortable, he knew this territory. He glided down the road, his breathing steady and smooth. Rob kept getting further behind, his breathing was labored. Billy won the race handily. Billy and Rob shook hands at the finish line, realizing neither one was better than the other. They both had their gifts.

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Questions for Billy

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. How did Billy like to get around?

2. Why do you think Billy likes to run?

3. Who wanted Billy to join the track team?

4. Why did Billy join the track team?

5. How do you know Billy was feeling good after the 1 mile race?

6. How did you know the 5K was a good race for Billy?

7. What were each boy's gifts?

8. Why do you think they shook hands after the last race?

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Brett

Brett and Lucy were twin sisters. They were alike in many ways. They were identical twins, so they looked and sounded so similar that sometimes people got them mixed up. Most of the time, Brett and Lucy thought it was funny when people confused them. But sometimes they got tired of being mixed up. Even though they liked many of the same food and activities, they also had different interests. For instance, Brett enjoyed drawing and Lucy loved to sing. Each of them spent time doing these things without the other.

But one day Brett heard Lucy singing and saw how her teacher gave Lucy extra time to sing solos in class. Brett really wished she could sing, too. She tried and tried but she couldn't make the same sounds or read the music. Brett told her mom that she wished she could sing like Lucy.

At the same time, Lucy saw some of Brett's drawings displayed in the hall at school and wished she could draw, too. Brett's art was often used as an example by her teacher. Lucy tried to draw, but she just couldn't get it right. She told her mom that she wished she could draw like Brett.

Their mother listened to each girl's comments. She told them that it was okay that each of them had different interests. They could enjoy each other's talent and be happy for them, knowing that each of them had a unique talent. She said if Brett spent as much time as Lucy singing, she wouldn't have time to draw. And, she said that if Lucy pursued drawing, she wouldn't have time for her singing. The girls listened to their mother and realized she was right. They could celebrate their similarities and their differences. And they would always be best friends and twins!

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Questions for Brett

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Why did people sometimes mix up Brett and Lucy?

2. Why would Brett and Lucy get tired of people mixing them up?

3. What activity did Lucy enjoy doing on her own?

4. Why did Brett feel sad when she heard Lucy singing one day at school?

5. What activity did Brett enjoy doing on her own?

6. Why did Lucy feel sad when she saw Brett's drawings displayed on the wall at school?

7. Who did the twins talk to about their feelings?

8. Why did their mother say it was okay for the girls to have different interests?

9. What did their mother say would happen if Brett wanted to sing more and Lucy wanted to draw more?

10. Did Brett and Lucy seem happy with their mother's advice?

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Cassie

Cassie was tired of getting picked last for soccer. She felt sad when everyone else got picked for a team but her. She wanted to become a better player so she wouldn't always be last. It was important to her.

Cassie asked her brother Will for help. Will was an excellent player and Cassie was sure that he would be able to help. The brother and sister went to the park after school. They took a soccer ball and two orange cones. First Will told Cassie to run as fast as she could up and down an imaginary soccer field. Will was couldn't believe how fast Cassie could run. He wished he could run that fast.

Next, Will set up the two orange cones at one end of the imaginary field. He put the ball at the other end and told Cassie to run and kick the ball and try to get it into the space between the cones. This turned out to be difficult for Cassie. She tried very hard but she couldn't control the ball. She ended up kicking the ball too hard or in the wrong direction. She tried over and over without success. Both Will and Cassie were getting frustrated and Will was starting to feel as bad as Cassie.

Cassie was ready to give up. Just then Mr. T, the gym teacher from their school, walked up. He'd been working with some kids in another part of the park. He had seen Cassie running and was impressed. He asked her to join a running club he was putting together after school. He said her speed would help them win races, if they decided to compete. Cassie was thrilled and Will was relieved. Mr. T had appeared at just the right moment.

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Questions for Cassie

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Cassie tired of?

2. Why was it important to her to get better at soccer?

3. Who did she ask for help?

4. Will and Cassie seem to have a good relationship. How can you tell?

5. What did Cassie and Will take with them to the park?

6. How can Cassie be good at running but not so good at getting the ball between the cones?

7. What went wrong when Cassie tried to get the ball between the cones?

8. Why was Will starting to feel as bad as Cassie?

9. Who came to talk to them?

10. Why did Mr. T's comments make both Cassie and Will happy?

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Eli

Eli's family was going to the zoo for the day. Eli was very excited to see the animals. He liked the farm area where people can pet the baby farm animals and help feed them. Last year he got to hold a piglet, pet a bunny, and feed a calf. But this year he was especially looking forward to visiting the new butterfly exhibit. He had studied butterflies at school and read about the new area with all kinds of butterflies flying around in a big room. He hoped one would land on him.

When they got to the zoo, everyone agreed to go to the butterfly exhibit first. To enter, they had to go into a small room and close the door behind them. This was to make sure butterflies didn't escape. Then they were allowed to go in the main room.

In the exhibit, there were plants and rocks and trees. Butterflies of all sizes and colors were flitting around the room. A big blue one landed on a leaf and slowly opened and closed its wings. Eli held his hand out toward it to see if it would land on him, but it didn't. He tried putting his finger close to an orange one in a tree, but it just flew away. He asked the zookeeper how to get a butterfly to land on him. She said to let the butterflies come to you.

Eli was getting discouraged and sat down on a rock. He watched some butterflies on a flower and suddenly he realized a butterfly had landed on his shoe. He was very excited but tried to hold very still. After awhile the butterfly flew away. Eli was so happy with his day at the zoo, especially with the butterfly exhibit.

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Questions for Eli

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Where was Eli's family going for the day?

2. Why was Eli so interested in the butterfly exhibit?

3. Where did they go first?

4. How did the small room keep butterflies from escaping?

5. What was in the exhibit room?

6. Why did the butterflies fly away when Eli tried to get them on his hand?

7. Where did Eli sit down?

8. Why did the butterfly land on Eli's shoe?

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Ezra

Ezra wanted to do something special for his mom on Mother's Day. He looked at some jewelry catalogs but everything was too expensive. He asked his dad for ideas. His dad said he thought something homemade would be special. His dad told him that when he was a boy he made his mother breakfast in bed on her birthday. Ezra decided he would make his mother breakfast in bed, too. His dad asked if he needed help, but Ezra said he wanted to do it by himself.

That night, Ezra set his alarm for 6:00 a.m. When the alarm went off the next morning it was still dark outside. Ezra used his flashlight and tiptoed into the kitchen. He turned on the light and got everything ready to make scrambled eggs. He cracked two eggs into a bowl and stirred them. He poured the eggs into a pan and turned the heat on.

While the eggs cooked, he set out a tray with silverware, a napkin, and a glass of juice. Next, he made some toast, buttered it and spread some grape jelly on it. Suddenly, he heard the eggs sizzling. Ezra turned off the burner and dished up the eggs. They were a little burnt, but not too bad.

Breakfast was ready. He carried the tray into his parent's bedroom where they were both still asleep. He walked next to his mom and said quietly for her to wake up. She opened her eyes and was so surprised. She sat up and Ezra put the tray in her lap. She told Ezra it was the best Mother's Day gift she could imagine. She had never had breakfast in bed before. Ezra's dad gave him a thumbs-up. His mom smiled as she ate the whole breakfast and Ezra explained how he had made it.

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Questions for Ezra

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What holiday was coming up?

2. Why did Ezra's dad say that a homemade gift was special?

3. What did Ezra set on the tray?

4. Why did Ezra set an alarm?

5. How many eggs did Ezra use?

6. What did the sizzling on the stove tell Ezra?

7. How did Ezra wake his Mom up?

8. How did Ezra know that his dad thought he did a good job?

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Gary

Gary was a city kid. He took the subway to school, played baseball in a parking lot, ate out in restaurants, and saw many movies at the local theatre. He had never been outside of the city in his ten years of life and he never wanted to.

Summer vacation was on the horizon. His parents decided it was time Gary experienced country life. So, they were sending him to his Grandma's country house. She lived about 200 miles north of the city. Gary was extremely apprehensive about staying somewhere that didn't have a restaurant or a movie theatre. He reluctantly climbed aboard the bus and waved good bye to his parents. As he saw them get smaller and smaller, he felt his world was going to get smaller too.

He arrived at Grandma's house three hours later, tired, hungry and very worried. Grandma's smile and her warm chocolate chip cookies made him feel better. As he settled in, Gary's outlook became more positive. The air seemed fresher, the sun seemed warmer, and there was so much room to play.

Gary and his Grandma's dog became fast friends. They would take long walks discovering toads in ponds, snakes slithering behind trees, and the many things you could do with mud and sticks. He would bring home his discoveries to Grandma. She welcomed them with open arms. Together, he and Grandma built bird houses. They enjoyed watching the birds and their new home. She even taught him how to make cookies. Gary learned that living in the city was fine, but living in the country can be just as much fun.

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Questions for Gary

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Name 3 things Gary did in the city.

2. Why was Gary so worried about going to the country

3. How did Grandma make him feel better?

4. Why did Gary and his Grandma's dog become friends?

5. Name 2 things Gary and Grandma's dog do together.

6. What do you think Grandma taught him?

7. Name 2 things Gary did with Grandma.

8. How did Gary feel about the country now?

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Jake

The Science Fair at school was next week and Jake still didn't know what to do. He had so many ideas. He wanted to pick the best one that would win. He thought of making a volcano, but someone did that every year. He thought of making clouds in a bottle, but he wasn't sure how to do it.

He decided to talk to his Science teacher, Ms. Olson. After class, Jake told her what his ideas were. She asked him what he was most excited about. He thought for a minute and then he said he really wanted to do something that showed the effect of melting polar ice caps and rising sea level. Ms. Olson encouraged him to do the idea that he was most excited about.

So, he decided he would do a project about the melting polar ice caps. He read about the subject and worked on different model ideas. He used a lot of ice from the family freezer. He melted the ice at different temperatures and measured the results. He found a great way to make a model of the earth using a ball. He worked so hard that sometimes he forgot to take a break for meals or to walk the dog. Jake was both exhausted and excited.

Finally, the day of the science fair came and Jake could show what he had been working on. At his booth, he talked to people about his project and answered their questions. Visitors to Jake's booth seemed to be impressed with his knowledge on the subject. In the end, he didn't win the blue ribbon but he was very proud of his work and his teacher was, too.

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Questions for Jake

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was coming up at Jake's school?

2. Was Jake excited to participate?

3. Who helped Jake decide what project to choose?

4. How did Ms. Olson help Jack make a decision?

5. What did Jake decide to do his project on?

6. How did Jake work on his project?

7. How could Jake be both exhausted and excited at the same time?

8. Why were visitors to Jake's booth impressed?

9. What prize did the best Science Fair project win?

10. Was Jake disappointed that he didn't win the blue ribbon?

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Jamal

Jamal's parents gave him a house key. He felt grown up carrying a house key in his pocket. Most of his friends had a key to their houses and now Jamal did, too. Jamal's parents told him to keep close track of it and to use it to let himself in the house after school. Jamal was responsible for letting the dog outside, getting himself a snack and starting his homework before his parents got home.

One day, after Jamal walked home from school, he reached into his pocket for the key, but it wasn't there. He thought it must have fallen out at recess and decided to walk the three blocks back to school to look for it. When he got to school he looked under the monkey bars. Then he looked under the tire swing. Finally, he looked under the slide. He did not find the key.

Jamal walked back home slowly. He was worried that his parents would be mad. When he arrived home, his mom was already there. She was in the back yard with the dog. She saw that he looked sad and asked him what was wrong. He explained about the missing key and his search for it. She asked him if he was sure that he had taken it to school. He thought that he had, but said he would double-check.

Jamal went inside and opened his dresser drawer. He saw his key. He had forgotten it this morning. He was so relieved. He raced outside to tell his mom. She was glad he found it and said they should talk about how to make sure he doesn't forget it again. Jamal was very happy as he got himself a snack and started his homework.

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Questions for Jamal

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did his parents give to Jamal?

2. Why did it make him feel grown up?

3. Where did Jamal think his key was?

4. Why did Jamal think he had lost it at recess?

5. Where was his mom when he got back home?

6. Why did she think Jamal might not have lost his key?

7. Where did Jamal find his key?

8. What might Jamal's mom suggest he does to remember to take his key with him?

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Judah

Judah and his friend Jeff were very interested in secret codes and loved reading books about spies. Sometimes they sent messages to each other that were in a secret code, but people could see it. What they really wanted to do was to send messages using invisible ink, but they didn't know how.

They began to research it and found the perfect solution. They made a list of supplies they needed and arranged to meet in their tree house that afternoon. Judah was supposed to bring a lemon, a cup and a knife. Jeff was going to bring some paper, cotton swabs and a flashlight.

When they got to the treehouse, the first thing they did was to make sure they hadn't been followed. Then they got started. They cut the lemon in half and squeezed the juice into the cup. Next they used a cotton swab to write a message on the paper with the juice. They could see the writing when it was wet, but when it dried it disappeared. The friends were getting excited.

To see if the invisible message would show up, the boys held the paper in front of the warm flashlight. They watched and waited to see if anything would happen. As the paper warmed up, the message written in lemon juice turned brown. It worked. Judah and Jeff gave each other their secret high five. Now they could write secret messages to each other that no one else could see.

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Questions for Judah

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did the boys read books about?

2. Why did Judah and Jeff want to use invisible ink?

3. What supplies was Judah supposed to bring?

4. Why did they meet in the treehouse?

5. What did the boys do with the lemon?

6. Why did a cotton swab work to write with?

7. What did the boys use to warm the paper?

8. Why did the boys do a secret high five?

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Liz

It was the start of summer and Liz wished she had a friend in her neighborhood. There were kids that were older and kids that were younger but none that were close to her age. The house next door had sold recently and Liz hoped the new family had someone her age. She loved to play sports in the yard but it wasn't much fun by herself.

One morning she heard some loud noises outside. She looked out the window and saw a moving truck. The movers were carrying boxes and furniture down a ramp from the truck to the house. The new neighbors were moving in. Liz was excited and a little nervous. She was worried that they might not have children.

Liz went outside and sat on her front step. She watched the movers and looked for any signs that would tell her if the new neighbors had kids her age. She saw a couch, a TV set and some mattresses. Then she saw a basketball hoop. Liz was getting excited. Next she saw a bag of soccer balls and some tennis racquets. Now she was certain they had kids, but it was hard to tell what age they were. When she saw four bikes, two of which looked like her size, she nearly jumped for joy.

A car pulled up. Two adults got out. And then she saw a girl and boy climb out from the back seat of the car. Both the boy and the girl looked about her age!

Liz ran over to the neighbors to introduce herself. The girl had a big smile on her face. She said she and her brother were hoping there would be some kids their age, too. Now Liz was looking forward to playing with her new friends this summer.

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Questions for Liz

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Liz wish she had?

2. Why would Liz want a friend to live close by?

3. What did Liz see one morning from her window?

4. Why was Liz both excited and nervous about the new neighbors?

5. What was the first thing Liz saw that made her think that children were part of the new family?

6. Why did Liz want to jump for joy when she saw the bikes?

7. Who got out of the car when it pulled up next door?

8. How do you think Liz felt when she first saw the new family?

9. How did the new neighbor girl look when Liz ran over to introduce herself?

10. What could Liz do to help her new friends feel comfortable in their new neighborhood?

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Lucas

Lucas, his mom and his brothers, were going downtown on the train for the first time. Before their mom could figure out how to buy tickets from the machine, the train arrived. Rather than miss it, she told the boys to get on. She said she would get the tickets at the next station.

This made Lucas very nervous. He was proud of being a rule-follower and knew this was definitely breaking the rules. Everyone knew you had to have a ticket before you got on the train. He'd heard his friends talk about the people they'd seen thrown off the train or even arrested for not having a ticket. He sure hoped they'd been exaggerating! As the doors opened at the next station, Lucas saw a policeman get on. His mom, chatting with his brothers, apparently forgot about getting the tickets at this station and didn't move. As the train lurched forward, Lucas' stomach dropped.

The policeman approached down the aisle. He seemed to be looking carefully at each passenger. Lucas wondered if he could tell just from looking who had not purchased a ticket. He tried to catch his mom's eye without saying anything. Finally she looked at Lucas. He jerked his head toward the policeman, trying to send a message that they were in serious trouble. He couldn't believe it when she called the policeman over. That wasn't what he'd wanted! Lucas prepared himself to be humiliated, arrested or thrown off the train, at the very least.

Lucas' mom explained their situation. The policeman thanked her for her honesty. He told her how to buy tickets at their final stop. As he wished them a good day, Lucas heaved a huge sigh of relief and realized that it already was.

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Questions for Lucas

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What were Lucas and his family doing for the first time?

2. Why might the family have gotten on the train even though they didn't have tickets?

3. What was Lucas proud of?

4. Why did he hope that the stories he'd heard from his friends were exaggerated?

5. Who got on the train at the next stop?

6. Why did Lucas try to get his mom's attention without saying anything?

7. What did his mom do that shocked Lucas?

8. Why did Lucas find that shocking?

9. What did the policeman do instead of getting mad at them?

10. Why did Lucas feel like they were having a good day after all?

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Maya

Maya's class was going on a field trip. It was a trip to a giant outdoor play area called Chutes and Ladders. Maya was excited, but nervous, too. She heard there were ropes and ladders and slides. She was worried everything would be too high and scary. Maya loved to play outdoors, but she didn't like heights. She was worried that she might not have fun or be able to keep up with her classmates if they all went on the high equipment.

When the class got on the bus, Maya sat next to her friend, Siad. They all sang songs and had a nice bus ride. When they got to the park, before they got off the bus, the teacher went over safety rules. She said she would blow her whistle to let everyone know when to meet at the picnic tables for lunch. Then she let them get off the bus. Most of the kids ran as fast as they could to the play equipment. They climbed up the ladders and ropes.

Maya and Siad walked slowly to the playground. Maya asked Siad why he wasn't running. He told her he was a little nervous to go up so high. That made Maya feel much better. She told him she felt the same way and so they decided to try explore together. Their teacher said there was something for everyone and showed them an area where there were some swings and fun things to climb on that weren't up so high.

They were having so much fun they didn't realize how much time had passed. When the teacher blew the whistle they all came running. Maya and Siad were having as much fun as all the other kids. They were glad they went on the field trip and that they could play together.

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Questions for Maya

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Where was Maya's class going on a field trip?

2. Why was Maya nervous?

3. Who did Maya sit with on the bus?

4. Why did the teacher need to use a whistle to call kids to lunch?

5. Where did the teacher show them to play?

6. Why did Maya and Siad walk slowly to play area?

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Mick

Mick's family was planning a celebration for his Grandpa's 80th birthday. It was going to be a surprise party. They had a meeting to talk about who to invite, where to have it and how to keep it a surprise. Mick was very excited.

First, they talked about where to have the party. They thought about the park where his grandpa walks every day, but if the weather was bad they wouldn't have anywhere to go. Plus, if they were outside it would be hard to hide and surprise him. They decided it should be inside. Nick knew his grandpa went bowling once a week. He suggested they have it there at the time he usually bowls. Nick's parents liked that idea so they began to work on the details.

Everyone had a job. Mick's mom called the bowling alley. Nick's dad sent invitations to grandpa's friends and their cousins. Mick and his sister offered to go to the bakery to order a cake. They chose a white sheet cake that said Happy Birthday to the world's best Grandpa. They also asked for a picture of bowling pins and a bowling ball on it.

Finally, it was the day of the party. They arrived at the bowling alley and everyone hid behind the counter. When grandpa came in, everyone popped up and yelled happy birthday and had balloons. Grandpa was very surprised. Mick showed him the cake. He had a tear in his eye and gave Mick a hug. Mick was happy it turned out so well and that it was a surprise.

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Questions for Mick

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Whose birthday was Mick's family celebrating?

2. What made the park not the best choice?

3. What job did Mick's dad do?

4. Why did Mick and his sister ask for bowling pins and a bowling ball on the cake?

5. Where did they hide at the bowling alley?

6. How could Mick tell that his Grandpa liked the cake?

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Nala

On the way home from the store, Nala heard a sound coming from under a bush. Nala peeked under the bush and a little grey kitten came bounding out. Nala picked up the kitten and it purred loudly. Nala waited to see if the owner would come by, but nobody did and it would soon be dusk. She decided to take the kitten home.

Her parents were surprised when Nala came home with the kitten. When Nala told them what had happened they agreed that she did the right thing. They said they could keep the kitten overnight and then go out to find its owners tomorrow.

Nala made a cozy spot for the kitten in the laundry room. Her dad got some kitten food and litter at the store. After the kitten ate, her tummy was big and round. Nala asked if she could sleep with the kitten so it wouldn't be lonely. Her parents said okay and brought her a sleeping bag. They slept until early morning when the kitten mewed for breakfast. After the kitten was fed, they all ate, too. Then they put the kitten in their red wagon and set out to find the kitten's owners.

They started where Nala found the kitten and knocked on the door to each house on the block. Then Nala noticed a piece of paper stapled to a telephone pole. It showed a picture of a lost grey kitten. They saw some kids with fliers at the corner. Nala and her parents called and the kids came running. They looked in the wagon and said it was their kitten. They were so happy and thanked them for taking care of her.

Nala was happy for them, but also sad to say good-bye to the kitten. Luckily, the kids told them where they lived and said Nala could visit anytime.

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Questions for Nala

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Nala find under a bush?

2. Why didn't Nala want to leave the kitten alone when it was getting dark?

3. How did Nala's parents feel when she brought home the kitten?

4. Why did Nala want to sleep with the kitten?

5. What did Nala and her parents use to take the kitten around the neighborhood the next morning?

6. Were Nala and her parents able to find the kitten's home right away?

7. What did they see on the telephone pole?

8. Why did Nala think the kids they saw were looking for the kitten?

9. What happened when the kids looked in the wagon?

10. Why was Nala both sad and happy when they kids took their kitten?

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Pat

Pat's family was on vacation. They were staying in a cottage at a lake. They spent most of their time down at the shore fishing, swimming, and making sand castles. Pat's dad also spent time finding stones and skipping them across the top of the water. Pat loved the way the stones bounced off the water. His dad skipped the stones and they counted how many times they touched the surface of the water and went back in the air. The record was 9, but most of them skipped 4 or 5 times. Pat wanted to skip stones, too.

Pat tried to skip some stones but when he threw them, the stones just made a big splash and sank to the bottom. He watched his dad pick up a stone and throw it so it skipped across the water. Pat asked his dad to teach him how to do it.

His dad said he would be delighted and said he remembered when his own father had taught him. He said first Pat needed to find flat stones. Pat looked along the shore and found some flat stones and put them in his pocket. He threw one but it still splashed and sank. Pat was getting frustrated.

His dad said Pat should throw the stone low and sideways, parallel to the water. He also said he should aim far out on the surface of the water rather than up close. He showed Pat in slow motion. Then Pat tried a few stones. It didn't work but his dad encouraged him to keep trying. On the third try, the stone skipped once. He was excited. He tried again and it skipped twice. His dad cheered. Pat jumped up and down. Now he had the feel for it. He would practice every day and skip stones with his dad.

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Questions for Pat

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Where was Pat's family staying on their vacation?

2. Why do you think Pat wanted to skip stones?

3. What happened when Pat first tried to skip stones?

4. Why do you think Pat's dad was delighted to teach Pat how to skip stones?

5. What kind of stones did he tell Pat to look for?

6. Why was Pat getting frustrated?

7. What did Pat's dad do next to help him?

8. Did Pat make the stones skip right away?

9. Why do you think he didn't give up?

10. Do you think it's possible that Pat might break his dad's record?

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Riley and Vada

Riley and her best friend Vada became very excited when they heard about the costume contest. Their school held the contest every spring and the prize was fifty dollars. They thought about all the things they could buy with the money. The girls knew they could divide the money and both be satisfied. They decided that if they put their heads together, they could create a masterpiece.

The girls went to Riley's house to look through her little sister's pretend, dress up clothes. There were a variety of options: tutus, hats, crowns, and necklaces. They tried many things on, but nothing seemed right. Riley's sister came in looking very upset, her face was red and she was shouting. They knew this was not going to work.

Next, they went to Vada's house to look through the stuff in her garage. There were old bike tires, boxes, a wooden barrel, some roller skates, rope, and other useless things. They looked at each other and almost cried.

Then an idea popped into Vada's head. Together, we can be a mule. Riley looked at her stunned and confused. Vada relayed her plan one step at a time. The box will become the head by attaching ears and eyes. The barrel will become the body of the mule and the roller skates will be the hoofs. One person gets in the back of the barrel and the other person is attached to the front of the barrel with a rope. They tried out the plan and it worked great. They were sure to win. At least, that's what they thought.

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Questions for Riley and Vada

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. Why did the girls want to enter the costume contest?

2. Why were they going to work together?

3. Name 3 things in the dress up box.

4. Why did the little sister get upset?

5. Name 3 things in Vada's garage.

6. Why did the girls almost cry?

7. What did they use to make the mule?

8. Why was Riley stunned and confused?

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Rosa

The Talent Show at school was coming right up. Rosa and her friends talked about what they were going to do in the show. Lars was going to play the violin, Sam was going to do gymnastics, and Ivan was going to Tap Dance. But Rosa couldn't think of a talent. She went home feeling sad.

That night, Rosa was very quiet so her parents asked her what was the matter. She told them about the Talent Show and how she couldn't think of a talent. Her mom asked her to think about what she most enjoys doing. Rosa thought for a minute. She said she loves playing with her dog, Spuds, and teaching him tricks. But Rosa didn't think that was a talent. Rosa's mom said it's a very special talent to work with animals with patience, and understanding. She suggested that Rosa could show some tricks she has taught Spuds at the Talent Show. Rosa said she would think about it.

The next day, she decided to give it a try. For a week, she worked with Spuds on some new tricks. She gave Spuds treats when he listened to Rosa and did what she asked. The day before the show, Rosa felt confident that they were ready. She was excited.

On the day of the Talent Show, Rosa wondered if she'd made a mistake. After all, no one else had brought a pet. When Rosa's name was announced, she walked Spuds to the center of the stage. Spuds didn't seem nervous at all and did everything just like they practiced. Rosa was so focused on Spuds she hardly noticed the audience. When they were done, Rosa heard loud cheering and looked out at the crowd. They were giving a standing ovation. Rosa was so proud of Spuds and so glad she could share her talent.

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Questions for Rosa

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was coming up at school that Rosa was worried about?

2. Why was Rosa sad about the Talent Show?

3. What did Rosa enjoy doing that she didn't think was a talent?

4. Why did Rosa's mom tell Rosa that teaching Spuds tricks was a "very special talent"?

5. How did Rosa reward Spuds when he learned new tricks?

6. Why did Rosa feel confident that they were ready?

7. Why did Rosa wonder if she'd made a mistake when she and Spuds went to the Talent Show?

8. Do you think it helped Rosa that Spuds didn't seem nervous?

9. What did Rosa hear and see when they finished their act?

10. What are some feelings Rosa probably felt at the end?

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Sara

Sara liked being an only child, after all she'd been one all her life. There were so many benefits: her own room, no one touched her things, but the best thing about being an only child is she didn't have to share her parents. She had them all to herself.

Then it happened, her mother announced one night that she was going to have a baby. Sara cried and cried. She had learned from her friends what it would be like: the crying, the smell from dirty diapers, baby stuff laying all over the house, the baby getting into your things. Her friends also said you have to be quiet all the time. The worst thing of all – you had to share your parents. Sara did not like sharing.

Sara told her parents all that she had learned. They tried to reassure her that they will always be there for her, always love her, and always take care of her. They reminded her that being a big sister is not all bad. Yes, there were things she'd have to share, but there were also many benefits. She'd always have someone to be with, someone to talk to, she'd never be lonely.

The fateful day arrived, her new baby brother was born. She got to hold him and she had to admit he was pretty cute. Baby Jimmy came home. They soon discovered he only smiled at Sara, he only stopped crying when Sara came in the room, and he was always following her with his eyes. He seemed to know who his best friend was going to be, and Sara did too.

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Questions for Sara

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was the best thing about being an only child?

2. Why do you think Sara was having such a hard time with having a baby brother or sister?

3. Name three things her friends told her about having a baby brother or sister.

4. Do you think Sara's parents made her feel better? How?

5. What was the name of her new brother?

6. What was unusual about Sara's brother?

7. What did Sara think of her brother when she first held him?

8. What did Sara discover at the end of the story?

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Stacey

Stacey enjoyed reading books and learning about science. She was especially interested in astronomy. She was excited to learn that there was a meteor shower each August called the Perseid Meteor Shower. It was scheduled to peak this week. Stacey wanted to see the meteor shower. She asked her mom if she could go outside to watch. Her mom said yes and asked if she could watch, too.

They read that the showers would be most visible after midnight. The forecast showed a clear sky for tonight. Later in the week it was supposed to be cloudy. It looked like this was going to be the best night for viewing.

They decided to get some sleep first and set an alarm to get up at 2:00 a.m. Before they went to bed they got everything ready by the back door. They laid out blankets, and bug spray, in case the mosquitos were out. Then they went to bed with their flashlights nearby.

When the alarm went off at 2:00 a.m., they got up with their flashlights, gathered their things and went outside. They settled into two lounge chairs in the back yard and looked up. The night sky was bright with stars.

At first they didn't see any meteors and Stacey was worried. But then she saw a streak of light through the sky. Then her mom saw one, too. They saw many, many meteors and stayed outside for almost an hour. Even though they were tired when they went back to bed, they both said they were glad they had gotten up to see the meteor showers.

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Questions for Stacey

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Stacey like to read about?

2. Why was Stacey excited about the meteor shower that was happening that week?

3. Why do you think Stacey's mom wanted to watch the meteor shower too?

4. What time did they set their alarm to get them up?

5. What did they do before they went to bed?

6. Do you suppose that Stacey had a hard time getting up at 2:00 a.m.?

7. Where did they go when the alarm woke them up?

8. Why would Stacey be worried when they didn't see any meteors at first?

9. What did Stacey and her mom finally see?

10. Do you think Stacey and her mom will watch other star shows in the future?

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Stan

Stan loved science class. He especially liked it when his teacher dressed up like scientists they were studying. She surprised them by doing this. She stayed in character and spoke in an accent, dressed like them, and talked about their life. So far, she had come as Jane Goodall and Benjamin Franklin.

This week they were studying genetics. Stan was disappointed when he came to class because his teacher was absent. There was a substitute teacher and he knew it was going to be boring. The substitute took attendance and asked the students to open their books. As they did this, she turned the lights out. Stan didn't know what was going on. He wondered if the power went out in the whole school. But then the substitute teacher did something strange. She lit some candles and turned on some music that sounded like chanting. The door to the class opened and someone came in dressed in long robes. It was their teacher! She greeted the class and explained that she was Dr. Gregor Mendel and would be teaching their class today.

Stan was relieved to see his teacher and excited to see what she would do as Dr. Mendel. She explained Dr. Mendel's life as a monk in Austria in the 1800's, before electricity. He lived a simple, quiet, religious life in a monastery and taught science. He also grew plants and studied how different characteristics in the plants were passed down. This became the scientific study of heredity. He is considered the founder of genetics.

Stan listened and after awhile forgot that it was his teacher dressed up. It was like having a real visitor from history answering questions for them. After class, as Stan left the candlelit classroom with the chanting music, he couldn't wait to find out what his teacher would do next.

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Questions for Stan

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What was Stan's favorite subject?

2. What did Stan's teacher do to make the class more interesting?

3. Why would Stan's teacher do that?

4. Why was Stan disappointed the day they started learning about genetics?

5. Did the substitute teacher turn out to be boring?

6. When Stan's regular teacher came into the room, who was she dressed as?

7. How would Dr. Mendel's quiet and simple life as a monk help him in his work?

8. Why would Dr. Mendel be considered the “founder” of genetics?

9. How can you tell that Stan's teacher did a good job of impersonating Dr. Mendel?

10. Do you think that Stan's teacher will continue to dress up and perform as other scientists?

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Steve

Steve couldn't wait to get home after school. For his birthday, he had gotten a new basketball and was excited to shoot some baskets in the driveway. He ran all the way home. But as soon as he changed his clothes and was ready to go outside, it started to rain. Steve was very disappointed.

Now Steve didn't know what to do. He moped around the house. Then he flopped down on his bed. His mom tried to cheer him up by saying it wasn't a big rainstorm and that it might clear up soon. Even though it was still raining, she pointed out that the sky was getting lighter in the west. She suggested Steve look for a rainbow. She said he should look to the east, with the lighter sky behind him.

Steve was still disappointed that he couldn't play basketball outside and said he didn't care about rainbows. But he was so bored, he decided to look out the window anyway. As he looked, he saw a small bit of color. It was getting brighter and started to make an arch across the sky. He could see red, orange, yellow, green, blue and purple. It was a rainbow! He threw his arms around his mom and squeezed her tight.

Steve stood and stared at the rainbow until it started to fade. It wasn't until then that he noticed that the rain had stopped. On his way out the door to shoot baskets, he gave his mom another squeeze and whispered a thank you.

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Questions for Steve

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did Steve get for his birthday?

2. Why was Steve so disappointed when it started to rain?

3. How did Steve's mom try to cheer him up?

4. Why did she suggest that he look for a rainbow?

5. Even though he wasn't interested in seeing a rainbow, Steve did what his mom suggested and looked out the window. Why do you think he did?

6. Which direction did he look for the rainbow?

7. What did Steve see in the sky?

8. Why did Steve give his mom a hug when he saw the rainbow?

9. When did Steve notice that the rain had stopped?

10. Why did Steve hug his mom again and whisper “thank you”?

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Xavier and Sue

Xavier along with his parents and older sister Sue moved into a new house. It was new to them however it was a very old structure. The ceiling leaked, the floors creaked, and they heard from the neighbors that the house was haunted.

They lived there only two days when Xavier noticed his favorite blanket was missing. He looked all over the house but couldn't find it anywhere. He asked his sister if she had seen it, she said she had not. He didn't know whether to believe her or not, just yesterday she hid his favorite marbles in the fish tank.

That night Xavier crawled into bed, he was about ready to doze off when he heard a noise. It sounded like a screeching; loud and disturbing. Then, there was knocking. He pulled the covers over his head. Sue flew into his room. She heard the noise too and was extremely frightened. Sue thinks the house is haunted and Xavier was starting to believe her.

The screeching came again. The next thing they knew, their parents were in Xavier's room. They too, were scared. Everyone decided to explore their new residence together. After they explored the bedrooms, kitchen, bathroom, and living room, there was only one room left. It was the attic! No one wanted to go up there alone. It was dark, dank, and full of cobwebs. They mustered up their courage and ascended the stairs together. They explored every nook and cranny. Screech! There it was again; very close and very loud. Xavier discovered an old wooden box. He looked in and saw a cat and her four babies. The kittens were fast asleep on Xavier's blanket. The mother cat was fearlessly protecting her young. No one wanted to get too close.

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Questions for Xavier and Sue

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What did the neighbors say about their house?

2. How did Xavier feel about his sister?

3. What was Xavier missing?

4. What did he think happened to his blanket?

5. What woke up Xavier?

6. Why did they explore the house together?

7. What did they discover in the attic?

8. How did they know the cat was protecting her babies?

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Stu

Stu always had such a hard time falling asleep. He felt tired when he was getting ready for bed, but as soon as his head hit the pillow and he turned off the light, he felt wide awake.

He couldn't get comfortable. He would turn to the right and the left, lay on his back and then his stomach. He was too hot and kicked the covers off or too cold. He listened to all the sounds in the house and felt wide awake. This seemed to go on for hours. The more he thought about it, the more wide awake he became.

Stu asked his dad what he should do. His dad said that he sometimes has the same problem. His dad told him what he does to relax. First of all, after he gets into bed at night he finds a comfortable position. Then, he thinks about relaxing his body. He starts at his toes, wiggles them a little and then relaxes them. Next, he thinks about his calves and flexes and relaxes them. He thinks about each part of his body from his toes to his nose and focuses on relaxing each area. His dad said that sometimes he is asleep before he even finishes. Stu said he would think about it.

That night, Stu gave it a try. At first he felt silly telling his toes to relax. But it gave him something to focus on and he could feel himself relax. By the time he finished, he didn't toss and turn so much and had an easier time falling asleep. The next morning, he told his dad that he had tried it and it worked. He was glad that he knew he could do that relaxation exercise every night and have an easier time falling asleep.

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Questions for Stu

Think about the story you just read and briefly answer these questions.

1. What happened when Stu went to bed at night?

2. Why did Stu get more wide awake as he tried to fall asleep?

3. Who did Stu ask for help?

4. What did his dad do to get relaxed for sleep?

5. When did Stu try the method his dad told him about?

6. Why did this exercise help Stu?

7. Did Stu fall asleep right away after doing the relaxation exercise?

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